The Absentminded King

By A.J. Jacobs

NARRATOR: **(Pg 117-124)** Once upon a time there was a king who was so good at his job, he was fit to be a king. Not only was he handsome and brave, but he had paid out the mortgage on his castle. And his carriage wasn't only beautiful, it also got good mileage. He even had a swimming pool shaped like a swimming pool. But for all this, he did have one little fault.

INTRODUCTION

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KING: *(Shouting)* Oh, honey, dearest!

SERVANT: Whom are you looking for, sire?

KING: My wife, the queen, that's whom!

SERVANT: But sire . . . you're not married.

NARRATOR: Yes, the king was so absentminded he couldn't seem to remember anything. He had even forgotten to marry. Knowing every king should have a queen, he discussed the matter with his prime minister.

KING: What shall I do?

PRIME MINISTER: First I suggest you put on your pants.

KING: Then what?

PRIME MINISTER: Find a wife.

NARRATOR: And so it was decided. The king put on his royal corduroys and called all the fair maidens to the castle so he could choose the most beautiful to be his bride. They came by the thousands.

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KING: And who are you?

GIRL #301: I'm a beautiful but underpaid servant girl from the country.

KING: Good! Go out back to the stables and take care of the horses. I think they're due for a waxing.

GIRL #301: But I didn't come here to wax the horses. I came to see if you want to get married.

KING: What would I want to get married for?

NARRATOR: Alas, the absentminded king had completely forgotten why the young ladies had been sent before him. And though he did hire three maids, a dishwasher, and five cooks, he failed to select a bride. When reminded of this fact, the king was very sad.

KING: If I'm ever going to get a queen, I'm going to need some help.

NARRATOR: He took a wishbone from his pocket -- one that he had been saving for just such an emergency. He snapped it, and surprisingly, got the biggest half, and said his wish.

KING: *(Screaming)* Help!

NARRATOR: With that, some tiny bells tinkled, a thunderous crash sounded, and an applause sign lit up. There appeared a beautiful blue fairy.

BLUE FAIRY: I am a magic blue fairy and I can help you get a queen.

KING: I'm all ears.

NARRATOR: (*aside --* The king could have been a body double in *Dumbo.)*

BLUE FAIRY: I know. But I can still help you get a queen.

NARRATOR: The fairy told the king that his queen lived in a castle on a mountain. But to get to her, the king first had to slay a terrible giant who guarded the castle. A tall order, to be sure-but not quite as hard as it sounded. The fairy gave the king a magic sword that would let him defeat the giant -- guaranteed, money back, minus shipping and handling. The king entered

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the woods and came face-to-face with the giant. Or actually face-to-knee with the giant. But in any case, the king was right next to the giant, and could have slain him on the spot, but for one thing: he had forgotten the magic sword. The giant picked the king up by the nose and tossed him over his shoulder. Luckily, however, when the giant threw him, he threw him nearer to the castle. So he actually passed the obstacle.

KING: Lucky for me. Okay. Now let's go get the princess.

BLUE FAIRY: Not so fast. Next you must pass through the huge, vicious thorn bush that surrounds the castle.

KING: Vicious thorn bush? There must be a catch.

BLUE FAIRY: As a matter of fact, there is. The secret is to be brave. The thorns will part to let a brave man pass.

NARRATOR: With that, the king steadied himself, and with all the speed he could muster, he ran headlong toward the vicious thorns. But also, true to form, he forgot to be brave. He chickened out. And that was not good for the king. He got ripped and scratched and poked. All his clothes were torn-except for his pants, of course, which he had forgotten to put on.

BLUE FAIRY: *(Sighing)* Oh, well. You did it again. But never mind. I'll just wave my magic wand and make those old vicious thorns disappear.

KING: Hey, why didn't you tell me could do that before?

BLUE FAIRY: You didn't ask me. *(She waves her wand)*

NARRATOR: And -- POOF! -- the thorn bushes disappeared. Now the king was really ready to go get his queen. But his troubles weren't over yet. This being a fairy tale, he had yet another test. He had to do away with the wicked witch who guarded his love.

KING: Okay. What's the gimmick with the wicked witch?"

BLUE FAIRY: I will give you a magic word that will make her disappear.

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KING: And that is . . . ?

BLUE FAIRY: Fundervogel!

KING: Wouldn't you know it. And me with the lousy memory.

NARRATOR: So, armed with the magic word, the king ran into the castle and found the wicked witch standing guard over his beautiful queen-to-be. Not expecting visitors, the witch hadn't had time to touch up her warts, so she was very unhappy to see the king. She decided to turn him into a toad and began to cast a spell.

WITCH: Iggilty piggilty, my black hen . . .

KING: *(Shouting)* Wait! I have a magic word that will make you disappear. And it is ... uh . . . And it is . . .

WITCH: Get on with it.

KING: And it is . . . Fundervogel!

NARRATOR: It was a miracle. The king had remembered the word and the wicked witch disappeared in a cloud of green smoke. But so happy was the king that he had finally remembered something, he completely forgot about the girl. He ran out of the castle, whistling gleefully and clicking his heels. Weeks went by, and of course, the absentminded king wandered around the countryside and failed to return to his kingdom, for he was unable to remember which kingdom was his. He finally chanced to pass a lovely young girl from whom he asked directions. And when she put her dainty finger to her chin to think over the question, the king noticed a little string tied around her finger.

KING: Pardon me, I couldn't help noticing that little string tied around your finger. What's it for?"

GIRL: Why, to help remember.

KING: Remember what?

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GIRL: I don't know . . . I forgot.

NARRATOR: The girl, you see, was as absentminded as the king, and needless to say that with such a common bond, they fell in love. And so it was that what's-his name married what's-her-name in a who's-its. And lived in a what-cha-ma-call-it happily ever . . . Oh, forget it.

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